

Departure Holiday Pay — Belgium

Payroll procedure for calculating holiday pay when a white-collar employee leaves the company

Country	Belgium (BE)	Applies to	All BE clients, white-collar statute
Product	Payroll	Effective from	1 January 2026
Owner	Payroll Expertise Centre BE	Supersedes	PAY-BE-PRC-014 v4.1; Payroll FAQ 2021 Q7

1. Purpose

This procedure describes how payroll consultants calculate the **departure holiday pay** (*vertrekvakantiegeld* / *pécule de vacances de sortie*) owed to a white-collar employee whose contract ends. It replaces all earlier guidance, including question 7 of the 2021 Payroll FAQ, which is no longer correct.

2. Principle

On leaving, the employer settles the holiday pay the employee has earned but not yet received. Two periods are always taken into account:

- **Previous calendar year (N-1)** — rights vested through work in the prior year and not yet paid out through holidays taken in the current year.
- **Current calendar year (N)** — rights accrued from 1 January up to and including the last day of employment.

Each period is settled at **15.34%** of the gross earnings of that period: 7.67% simple holiday pay plus 7.67% double holiday pay. Holiday pay already paid for days taken in year N is deducted from the N-1 amount.

3. Rates and bases

Component	Rate	Basis	Remarks
Simple departure holiday pay	7.67%	Gross earnings of the period, incl. variable pay	Paid with the final salary
Double departure holiday pay	7.67%	Same basis as above	Subject to the special holiday-pay withholding tax scale
Total per period	15.34%	Per period (N-1 and N)	Pro-rated automatically for part-time work via the earnings basis

4. Worked example

An employee earns € 3,600 gross per month, full-time, and leaves on 30 April 2026. In 2026 the employee already took 5 holiday days, paid as normal salary.

Step	Calculation	Amount
Earnings N-1 (2025)	$12 \times € 3,600$	€ 43,200.00
Departure holiday pay N-1	$€ 43,200 \times 15.34\%$	€ 6,626.88
Less: holiday pay for 5 days taken in 2026	per payroll records	– € 1,080.00
Earnings N (Jan–Apr 2026)	$4 \times € 3,600$	€ 14,400.00
Departure holiday pay N	$€ 14,400 \times 15.34\%$	€ 2,208.96

Step	Calculation	Amount
Total departure holiday pay		€ 7,755.84

Common mistake. Consultants regularly calculate only year N ("rights reset each January"). This is wrong and leads to underpayment. Always include N-1.

5. Holiday certificate

Together with the final pay slip the employer issues the **holiday certificate** (*vakantieattest*) for years N-1 and N. The next employer uses it to avoid paying the same holiday days twice. The certificate is generated automatically in the payroll engine once the leaving date is registered.

6. Blue-collar employees

Blue-collar holiday pay is paid by the holiday fund (RJV/ONVA or a sector fund), not by the employer. This procedure does not apply to them.

7. Change history

Version	Date	Change
4.2	January 2026	Clarified deduction of holiday days already taken in year N.
4.1	March 2024	Added worked example; aligned with holiday certificate flow.
4.0	June 2022	Corrected rule: N-1 must be included (FAQ 2021 Q7 withdrawn).